

Shame and Prejudice:

*Psychoanalysis, Homosexuality
and Othering*

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“Analytic theory presupposes a heterosexual norm. This is not surprising in terms of its original context. What is surprising is what might be seen as the tenacity of the profession’s attachment to this presupposition and the security of its position in the analytic canon, to this day.”

(Fonagy & Allison, 2015, p. 81)

“Homosexuality has been among the most controversial topics in the history of psychoanalysis.”

(Auchincloss & Samberg, 2012, p. 98)

In this paper I would like to draw our attention to the history of homosexuality within psychoanalysis. Particularly I want to consider our ancestry and the heterosexist history within which our theories and training sit. Psychoanalysis and psychoanalytic training institutes are underpinned by heterosexism that often goes ignored, or at least not discussed. Drescher (2016, p. 126) suggests of the US experience, “despite a few efforts to talk about what happened,

mostly by gay and lesbian analysts, on the whole there has not been much discussion about this shameful past.” I will consider the socio-historical context of psychoanalytic views of homosexuality, including the role of the sociodynamics of prejudice and hate. In this manner, psychoanalysis has at times mirrored the socio-historical mores, and can be considered to have played its part in reproducing the prejudices and systems of othering of the time. I will explore how classical Oedipal theorising is an important lynchpin of the hetero-normative stance of psychoanalytic theory, and I will explore how we might free ourselves from a classical Oedipal formulation. In closing, I will propose that heterosexist and homophobic psychoanalytic theories of homosexuality might serve defensive purposes of keeping hated parts of the individual and the group—that being homosexual parts, including all that has come to be associated with that term—split off and projected into the other and the “othered” group, and held at a distance.

I would like to begin with an excerpt from an interview with Hanna Segal conducted in 1990; this interview sets the scene well for the discussion to follow.

JR: Isn't there a danger (and do you think that psychoanalysts should take account of this) of complicity between the idea of a perverse personality structure and very widespread and quite dangerous attitudes against homosexuals as “perverts”.

HS: Most analysts today ask: “What do you mean by perversion?” And yes, we do have to be careful, but we can't follow fashions either way. I have had homosexual patients who came to be cured for all sorts of other things but who wanted to preserve their lifestyle. It just doesn't work as everything has to be analysed. To come back to your saying that analysts, and Kleinians in particular, are homophobic, I think there is a confusion here between clinical judgement and an attitude of moral superiority. An analyst, worth his salt, knows about illness from the inside. He doesn't feel, “You are a pervert unlike me.” He feels, “I know a bit how you came to that point, I've been there, am partly still there.” If he believes in God, he would say: “There but for the grace of God go I.” But my clinical judgement is that homosexuality is of necessity a narcissistic condition, as the name itself betrays. Loving homo—the same as me not hetero—the other, different. Heterosexuality can be more or less narcissistic. In homosexuality it's inbuilt.

JR: And yet Freud talked of bisexual dispositions in all of us.

HS: That was our trouble with the Wolfenden Report—how to convey both that a homosexual part of the self is normal—we identify with both parents—and yet we consider the adult homosexual structure to be pathological. But that is true of all infantile traits. We must be aware of that as part of us and yet other more mature choices have to be made.

JR: But doesn't that link between homosexuality; "immaturity" and "choice", reinforce prejudice against homosexuals, especially in the current climate of the backlash against homosexuals? I am thinking of the AIDS scare and Section 28.

HS: The backlash against homosexuality mobilised by AIDS is horrible. But not surprising—we always look for pariahs: Jews, blacks, homosexuals and the diseased—the lepers. I do not think analysts ever contribute to that. (Rose, 1990, pp. 254–255)

I will return to Segal's comments later, and in the spirit of our profession, I will begin now with Freud.

Freud: A Juvenilised Sexuality

Homosexuality has had a difficult birth in the canon of psychoanalysis. It has been the delinquent child, a child of arrested development and psychosexual retreat. Freud seemed to hold ambivalent views with regard to homosexuality. He didn't pathologise it, *per se*, but rather juvenilised it (Drescher, 1998). He viewed homosexuality as betraying "a certain arrest of sexual development" (Akhtar, 2009), and he placed inversion among three deviations with respect to the sexual object, alongside bestiality and paedophilia (Akhtar, 2009). On the other hand, he did not view it as an illness, and did not hold much hope that homosexuality was amenable to change through analysis. Freud believed that everyone was capable of making a homosexual object choice, and indeed had done so unconsciously (Abrevaya & Thomson-Salo, 2015). He theorised that the infant is born poly-morphously perverse, and that all humans have a constitutional bisexuality (Auchincloss & Samberg, 2012). Furthermore, he advocated several times that many homosexuals have turned out to be great cultural contributors, which he ascribed to a sublimation of their homosexuality. One of the most accessible statements Freud made regarding homosexuality was in his "Letter to an American Mother." He stated: "Homosexuality is assuredly no advantage, but it is nothing to be ashamed of, no vice, no degradation; it cannot be classified as an illness; we consider it to be a variation of the sexual function, produced by a certain arrest of sexual development" (Grotjahn, 1951, p. 331).

Freud's complex and contradictory views with regard to homosexuality can be understood from two angles. His theory of sexuality is largely a teleological one informed by Darwinian thought in which heterosexual genitality is viewed as the mature sexual outcome, because it gives rise to reproduction of the species. Consequently, sexual activity not involving vaginal intercourse is viewed as either

fore-pleasure—on the way to vaginal intercourse—or immature, pre-Oedipal and pre-genital. As a result, the theory is inherently moralistic and as Schafer states:

The word pregenital ... is closely allied to the word preoedipal, even though it does establish a somewhat different centre of interest. I maintain that “preoedipal” is also a teleological, implicitly moralistic term. It naturalizes a normative development that has been, from Freud on, usually understood in the sense of the positive Oedipal, the crystallization though not the culmination of heterosexual development (Schafer, 1995, p. 197)

On the other hand, Freud was decidedly in opposition to sexual conservatism and prudishness (Akhtar, 2009), and hence it can be understood that he was endeavouring to steer a course between these two opposing positions.

The Kleinians and Post-Freudians: A Pathological Structure

Fonagy and Allison suggest that “while it is ‘ungrateful’ to judge Freud on the basis of his milieu, it is legitimate to consider how its repercussions have been passed down onto subsequent generations of theory and practice, and at what cost” (2015, p. 84). Those who followed Freud have often further pathologised homosexuality, and Fonagy and Allison (2015) suggest that an emerging open-minded view of homosexuality under Freud was exchanged for Anglo-Saxon social acceptability: “Freud’s open attitude gave way to a vindictive pathologising theory that reflected the predominant values within the United States and Great Britain” (p. 128). This is especially apparent in Kleinian theory where a homosexual structure is viewed as innately pathological.

I began this paper with a quote from Segal which captured well the Kleinian position, she said: “homosexuality is of necessity a narcissistic condition” (Rose, 1990, pp. 254–255). Kleinians view homosexuality as a narcissistic object choice and a retreat to earlier states of immature, infantile psychosexual development. The reason proposed for the retreat is an attack on the parental couple, a denial of the facts of life, and an avoidance of the primal object. Klein suggests that while gay men and lesbians may have good object relations, such relations are deceptive, hiding underlying split off envy toward the primal object that remains operative and liable to disrupt object relations (Klein, 1957/1975). Meltzer similarly viewed homosexuality as a perversion with different causes including “narcissistic disorder (sodomasochistic wishes), defences against depressive anxieties, infantile zonal confusions” (O’Connor, 2010a, p. 39), and he

equated homosexuality with “infantile foreplay” (Maquire, 2004, p. 136). Winnicott viewed homosexuality as a “return to a pre-oedipal state and a flawed cross gender identification [(Winnicott, 1964)]” (Fonagy & Allison, 2015, p. 87).

More recently, Limentani (1977) has argued that homosexuality is a defensive solution to a variety of neurotic and psychotic anxieties. Khan is well known to have been homophobic, and Godley wrote that during his problematic treatment with Khan he overheard a telephone call during which Winnicott and Khan shared “a giggly joke about homosexual fellatio” (Dimen, 2001). Soccarides, who was a vocal opponent of gay men and lesbians being admitted to psychoanalytic training institutes, stated in a Washington Times article in 1994 “that homosexuality cannot make a society or keep one going for very long. It operates against the cohesive elements of society. It drives the sexes in opposite directions, and no society can long endure when either the child is neglected or the sexes war with each other” (Ellis, 2015, p. 11). Much of what Soccarides said appears hauntingly similar to statements from the Australian Christian Lobby in opposition to marriage equality. There are many many other examples of this kind of attitude scattered throughout the psychoanalytic literature. These views are the norm as opposed to the exception. The exception would be the relational, inter-subjectivist, feminist schools of thought.

Not all psychoanalytic thinkers have viewed homosexuality as pathology and Balint, arguably writing well before his time in 1956, suggested that it’s not sex but love that matters. He recommended that homosexuality not be viewed as a perversion because “homosexuals experience ‘practically the whole scale of love and hatred that is exemplified in heterosexuality’, because ‘all the beautiful, all the hideous, all the altruistically loving and all the egotistically exploiting features of heterosexual love can be found in homosexual love as well’” (Balint, 1956).

Many reasons can be put forward to explain the continuing ill treatment of homosexuality in psychoanalysis. I will focus on two that I think are important to discuss further: (i) the centrality of classical Oedipal theorising; and, (ii) processes of projection, prejudice and othering. However, there is another reason that I want to raise briefly. In the earlier Segal quote she implored: “we can’t follow fashions either way.” Her comment betrays what appears to be a general distrust in psychoanalytic circles of contemporary psychoanalytic theory. I would suggest we are inculcated into this distrust in our training when the initial focus is on a deep exploration of Freudian and Kleinian theory prior to approaching anything more modern, and usually with less depth.

In a similar vein, a supervisor once remarked to me that contemporary psychoanalytic thought ought to be regarded with caution. This comment captures how frequently our ancestry is held in a state of reverence, and any contemporary

rethinking or critique of their contributions is seen as suspicious, and at worst as an attack. This appears to lead to a defensive holding on to the past, a fear of difference, and dubiousness about new, creative and critical contributions. There is a not so subtle message to toe the line and not question the authority of our analytic forefathers and foremothers and in this way they become gods, and their theories are held as “truth” and proven. What began as abstractions, ideas, or heuristics (Holmes, 2014) for making sense and building understanding, can become reified as “truths”. The British Psychoanalytic Council, a confederate of psychoanalytic and psychotherapy institutes, warned exactly of this closed mentality in a communiqué to its member institutes as recently as June 2015. It called for an opening up to creative thinking about psychoanalytic approaches to gender and sexuality warning that it is “high time we looked beyond our own borders, to open up a dialogue with the outside world” (Newbigin, 2015). Bion also warned us of the reification of psychoanalytic concepts:

A brilliant idea, [Bion] thought, was like a cut, a caesura. Bion (1989) developed this metaphor of the caesura in unexpected directions: much like the birth of an infant, so too, the birth of an idea. And much like the way we are entranced at the moment of birth, we turn our heads when a great idea or paradigm emerges. Paradox enters because the very idea that gave rise to a new theory and way of thinking can also give rise to the danger of a stasis in growth and paralysis. Bion was concerned about our tendency to be captured by ideas, to turn them into religions, or ultimate truths, leading to a loss in our freedom of thought. (Biran, 2015, pp. 67–68)

I would suggest that Oedipal theorising is one such place where stasis has occurred in our thinking, the Oedipus complex is sometimes held as a “truth” and beyond questioning, as opposed to an heuristic which ought to be held more loosely and with a fuller recognition of the inability to validate empirically such an idea (Newbigin, 2015). It seems in some circles a rethinking of Oedipal theorising is equivalent to psychoanalytic heresy. There is much resistance and it is difficult to challenge psychoanalytic orthodoxy, and we ought to continue to think about why.

The Centrality of the Freudian /Kleinian Oedipus Complex

For the Freudian and Kleinian schools the Oedipus complex is considered so central that for some it is suggested that questioning the centrality of the Freudian

Oedipus complex is akin to challenging the bedrock of psychoanalysis (Drescher, 1998). The Freudian/Kleinian child is conceptualised as needing to “positively” negotiate the Oedipus complex in order to negotiate healthy adult functioning, of which heterosexual genitality is part, as well as “the creation of the incest barrier, acceptance of generational boundaries, entry into the temporal dimension of life, respect for the value of waiting and effort, and formation of the super-ego” (Akhtar, 2009, p. 197). The positive resolution of the Oedipus Complex is seen as the “sine qua non of a male [and female] heterosexual identity” (Drescher, 1998, p. 230). Non-successful negotiation of the Oedipus complex is implicated in psychopathology including homosexuality. Given the centrality of Oedipal theorising in psychoanalytic theory, it seems worth inspecting more closely the case upon which the Oedipus Complex was theorised.

Ken Corbett (2009), a New York based psychoanalyst, wrote a fascinating reconsideration of little Hans, the preeminent psychoanalytic child and Freud’s first little Oedipus. He suggests that Freud was looking for a Hans, and quotes Freud: “long before he was in the world ... I had known that a little Hans would come who would be so fond of his mother that he would be bound to feel afraid of his father because of it” (Freud, 1909/1955, p. 42). This suggests that Freud had an *a priori* interpretation of Hans, an interpretation searching for a boy, as it were. Corbett proposes that Freud overlooked, and in fact disavowed, important aspects of Hans’s situation in a rush to make Hans a little Oedipus. Corbett (2009) draws on interviews released from the Freud archives in 2005, in which Kurt Eissler conducted interviews with both Max Graf (Hans’s father) and Herbert (Hans) Graf in the 1950s.

Freud had a complex relationship with the Graf family, beginning with his treatment of Olga Graf (Hans’s mother) while Max and Olga were courting. Hans is quoted as saying that his mother had complaints of Freud and that he had interfered in various ways in their life. Hanna, Hans’s sister, who suicided as a young adult, wrote to Eissler saying that Freud “wreaked havoc on us” (Corbett, 2009, p. 35). There seems to be a remarkable degree of trans-generational trauma in the Graf family, particularly on Olga’s side; one of Olga’s sisters made a suicide attempt, and both brothers successfully suicided by shooting themselves. Olga was reportedly neglectful of Hanna, and she had wanted a boy instead. Repeated descriptions of Olga paint the picture of a mother turned inward, and gripped by her own anxieties, unable to “take in another” (p. 34). A mother described as socially anxious, avoidant, depressive, hysterical, and insecure. Max says, “there was trouble between my wife and everybody” (p. 32). The marriage between Max and Olga lasted 18 years, and by Max’s account he had stayed for the children, but was left wondering if in fact, it might have been better to leave earlier. It

leaves the reader with the sense that Hans was a distressed boy in a distressed family. Hans refers frequently in his interviews with Eissler to the “personal misery” (p. 41) of the discord between his parents.

Corbett suggests that the symptoms Hans presented may well have communicated something more than his Oedipal yearnings, but Freud suggests his reading and interpretation of the Hans case to be “proved beyond a shadow of a doubt” (Freud, 1909/1955, p. 145). My intent here is not to throw the original psychoanalytic Oedipus out with the bath water, so to speak, but to raise the possibility that what Freud interpreted as Hans’s Oedipal yearnings might be seen in a different and more complex light in a re-reading of the case. Corbett (2009) suggests that Freud had before him a family in considerable distress, and that Hans was “a boy who was also likely trying to communicate something about his experience of his family as troubled” (p. 41).

Corbett (2009) reinterprets the possible meanings of the horse, the central symptomatic figure and symbol in the case in following way:

Might we read the falling horse as a beast of burden, as the stumbling, falling family, as the relations crumbling under the weight of two children and a deteriorating marriage? Might we read Hans’s description of the commotion of the feared falling horse as indicative of his experience of his parents’ relationship, witnessed arguments, fallings out, rows (in fact, row is the word Hans uses to describe the troubled horse)? Or might such commotion be the swirling hysteria of four people in a family losing hold? Similarly, one could view the feared horses bite as the wound of parental discord, or the bite of Hans’s taxed state of mind, or the bite of his mother’s castration threats, or the bite of his mother’s seeming objections to Freud’s ideas...the horse, especially as Hans elaborates his fantasies of beating it, could be seen to represent a scene of abuse: his mother’s beating of his younger sister...the row Hans describes can be heard as an echo of Hans’s description of the “row” Hannah (aged eighteen months) makes when beaten by her mother. Or could it be the row of Hans’s mind as he tries unsuccessfully to mentally outrun the abuse? (pp. 43–44)

Corbett (2009) suggests that many modern analytic practitioners do not hold to Oedipal theorising as it has been classically espoused, but prefer to think of the developmental experience of the triangulated “Oedipal” situation. A situation where the child begins to negotiate and learn of his erotic desires, alongside his attachment experiences; as a triangulated situation in which the child can observe desired others in relation, notably the Oedipal parents. It helps him/her through observing others, to think about how he wishes and how he desires and

reaches, to observe others' desires and reaches, and to begin contemplating the "minds and desires of others" (p. 40).

Corbett (2009) asserts that tradition Oedipal theorising is not a trans-historical truth, but a way of thinking that "disappoints as often as it succeeds in illuminating" (p. 40). Davies (2003) similarly advocates that in contemporary psychoanalytic theory, the Oedipus complex has "fallen into relative disfavor [sic]" (p. 7), and Leowald (1979) has also written of a waning of the Oedipus complex as psychoanalytic interest has turned to pre-oedipal concerns. Davies (2003) does not advocate an abandoning of the Oedipus complex per se, but a broadening of its remit from a theory of normative heterosexual development to focusing on the developmental achievement of shifting from primarily incestuous to non-incestuous object relations. She envisages a relational reframing of the Oedipus complex which allows for "postoedipal forms of relatedness in the evolution and integration of a richly textured, highly nuanced capacity for romantic passion and erotic sensual vitality" (p. 7).

This has the advantage of uncoupling the Oedipal situation from traditional notions of normative gender and sexuality, where, in the case of the boy, masculinity is not equated with heterosexuality, and femininity with homosexuality. It opens up the possibilities of our thinking and brings us more closely in relation to the reality of lived lives where "multiple pathways lead to an assortment of potential outcomes, focused not on sexual orientation or object choice but, rather, on the particular qualities of intimacy, eroticism, and a deeply resilient mutuality" (Davies, 2003, p. 7). A rethinking of Oedipal theorising can uncouple it from the binary thinking of man, masculinity, "father" and penis, and woman, femininity, "mother" and vagina. Which seems to be borne out in modern society where children of same-sex parents, by and large, establish a stable sense of their own blend of masculinity and femininity (Abrevaya & Thomson-Salo, 2015). In a similar vein, Fonagy and Allison (2015) also suggest "unwavering adherence to the Oedipal model makes it difficult to think creatively about sex and gender. The heterosexual norm is the fulcrum on which [Freudian] Oedipal identity balances" (p. 88).

These ideas help us to move beyond binary notions of man/woman, feminine/masculine, homosexual/heterosexual, normal/perverse. Fonagy and Allison (2005) have suggested that such binary thinking is a form of paranoid schizoid thinking, or a lack of mentalizing, and similarly Schafer (1995) criticised binary thinking in our conceptions of sexuality and gender. As early as 1948, Kinsey and colleagues (Kinsey, Pomeroy, & Martin, 1948) were documenting that sexuality does not in reality fall into binary categories, but that pure homosexuality and heterosexuality can be seen as ends of a continuum. For a modern Kinsey,

it is worth taking a look at Kahr's (2007) study of the sexual fantasies of over 19000 British people. He refers to the extraordinary panoply of sexual fantasies he came across as a "Noah's Ark of sexual fantasies, containing examples of everything that a human being could possibly imagine" (p. 383). Last, a study was recently published and received worldwide media attention, with various headlines such as "No Woman Totally Straight." Beyond the sensationalist headings, the authors (Rieger, Savin-Williams, Chivers, & Bailey, 2015) conclude that as far as arousal goes, in their study of 345 women, no woman was "totally straight" and just aroused by the opposite sex.

Why Do "We Always Look for Pariahs"? Processes of Othering

I would now like to turn to my final consideration of the problematic treatment of homosexuality in psychoanalysis. Again, Segal will help lead the way. In singling out Segal for critique, I do not mean to suggest she is alone in her views; her interview has just been a helpful springboard for this discussion. She said in her interview with Jacqueline Rose:

HS: The backlash against homosexuality mobilised by AIDS is horrible. But not surprising—we always look for pariahs: Jews, blacks, homosexuals and the diseased—the lepers. I do not think analysts ever contribute to that. (Rose, 1990, pp. 254–255)

"I do not think analysts ever contribute to that," is a thoughtless comment by Segal, and one that underestimates the regard and authority with which many have held psychoanalytic theory and practice. It also does not acknowledge how many psychoanalytic concepts have become popularised, pop-psychoanalytic one might say. For example, it is not uncommon to hear the distant father, binding mother theory of homosexuality, and this has sadly been used by psychoanalytically informed reparative therapies that have done great damage to gay men and lesbians. I agree with Fonagy and Allison (2015) when they suggest of the psychoanalytic stance on homosexuality: "nor has the stance been a neutral one—psychoanalysis has been both a follower and a promoter, without apparent pause for thought" (p. 81). One could suggest, that in their way, analysts have been central to the "pariah-ing" of gay men and lesbians, at best their theories of homosexuality have certainly not helped. We see a step in the right direction when the British Psychoanalytic Council's communiqué of June 2015 acknowledged the deep and lingering suspicion of psychoanalysis in the LGBT community and the need for

“explicit recognition of the suffering that the psychoanalytic stance has caused in the past” (Newbigin, 2015).

Segal’s comments help us though to further illuminate a socio-dynamic process. She said “we always look for pariahs,” and it is worth asking, why do we always look for pariahs? Seeking pariahs involves a process called othering, where a group of people is vilified, and in the minds of the group doing the othering, they are seen as “not one of us” (Gabriel, 2012; Jensen, 2011). This is very close to Freud’s idea of the “narcissism of minor differences” (Freud, 1921/1955, 1930/1961; Gabriel, 2012). It is “a process that goes beyond ‘mere’ scapegoating and denigration—it denies the Other those defining characteristics of the ‘Same’, reason, dignity, love, pride, heroism, nobility, and ultimately any entitlement to human rights” (Gabriel, 2012). In othering, powerful processes of splitting, projection and projective identification are in operation, and as Shafer (2007) pointed out, the power of these processes increases exponentially when employed by groups. Hinshelwood (1983) also noted the extensive use of projective processes in large groups. From a psychoanalytic point of view, the term “othering” could be confused with the term “other.” Relating to the “other” we understand to mean grappling with how to relate to the other as a separate, different and whole object. Othering, conversely, involves imbuing the group with projections of hated split off parts, so in effect, it’s a sort of narcissistic process involved in othering, we’re defining them. It does not involve relating to the other as a separate and whole object to be discovered. There isn’t desire to discover the members of the othered group in their unique difference or their similarity. This might bring to mind Australia’s treatment of asylum seekers, literally kept at a distance on Manus and Nauru.

Consequently, the group which has been othered is related to as if it were homogenous and undifferentiated, and furthermore, the more distant the othered group, the greater tendency to obliterate individual differences within that group (Shafer, 2007). We see this very process in action when Segal stated: “heterosexuality can be more or less narcissistic. In homosexuality it’s inbuilt.” She allows for difference and heterogeneity in the heterosexual group, more or less, but homogenises the homosexual group, it’s inbuilt. Furthermore, she stated earlier that “homosexuality is of necessity a narcissistic condition,” and then uses a trick of semantics, that homo implies same, and thus narcissism, to justify her homogenising statement. I suggest that Segal is both othering homosexuals and displaying Freud’s narcissism of minor differences. Her inability in this instance to hold a more diverse view of human sexuality is a view that homogenises homosexuals, a view that could be seen as threatened by difference, and comfortable with sameness. Homogenising processes such as this are enabled by fusion

statements (Shafer, 2007) such as; “women are weak,” “men are strong,” “blacks are primitive,” “Jews are miserly,” “gays are promiscuous.”

These processes are at the heart of prejudice and hatred (Shafer, 2007; Young-Bruehl, 1998), prejudice is a form of hatred. And groups, just like individuals, operate at a basic level by taking in good parts and getting rid of bad; it is into othered groups that the bad parts are projected. Can we not wonder whether the treatment of homosexuality by psychoanalysis has, by and large, been a process of othering where a homogenised homosexual group has received the projected hated parts of the heterosexual majority? The bad, promiscuous, narcissistic, immature, preoedipal, and oedipally conflicted parts? It is a painful indictment of psychoanalysis that it has, with regard to homosexuality, very much struggled to bear the difference of otherness, and to reflect on the pathologising, heteronormative position it has taken. As O'Connor states: “the psychoanalytic enterprise of equating human subjectivity with the truth of sexuality is a construal of human relationships in terms of a totalizing knowledge, the refusal of difference and otherness” (2010b).

In finishing, I would like to suggest that processes of prejudice, othering, and projection give rise to much of the difficulty and pathology experienced by gay men and lesbians. The noxious influence of cultural difference is rarely a focus of psychoanalytic thinking, and the British Psychoanalytic Council acknowledged that “the psychological impact of cultural difference has always been conspicuously overlooked as a serious subject of study in psychoanalytic and psychotherapy training” (Newbigin, 2015). Young-Bruehl suggests that “the victimization and victim status of homosexuals produced disturbances in them” (1998, p. 139 see also Auchincloss & Samberg, 2012, p. 98). It seems to me much of the difficulty and pain that our non-heterosexual patients present with is due to the prejudice and othering processes they have endured throughout their life. As with other minority groups, they suffer the shame of otherness. This is not to locate all the difficulty in the external world, but to acknowledge the role of societal attitudes in the constant interplay of reality and fantasy in the building up of the internal world and personality. It is a difficult task to negotiate a positive non-heterosexual identity and one which we as therapists ought to help our patients negotiate. Part of that process involves continuing to engage in thoughtful critique of the systematic ways our theories remain prejudiced against non-heterosexual people.

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